

League Director

A Pokémon-Inspired Idle/Tycoon Concept

Working title — concept draft v1

1. Premise

You are not a Trainer. You are the **Director of the Pokémon League** — the institution that outlives any single champion, gym leader, or challenger. Trainers rise, fall, get suspended, retire, or steal your title outright, but the League itself is the thing the player builds, defends, and grows over time.

This reframing is the answer to the genre's core problem: idle Pokémon-likes collapse into "one overleveled mon carries a team of duplicates you can't use." By making the player the *institution* rather than a trainer, every duplicate, every weak mon, every mediocre recruit has a job to do

somewhere in the org chart. Nothing is dead weight; everything is headcount.

2. Core Loop

A session is built around three kinds of time:

Passive (offline) time

- Assigned Catchers and Battlers keep producing (captures, income) at rates capped per-assignment by route difficulty and role level ceilings.
- No runaway snowballing — a single lucky trainer cannot silently outpace the whole roster overnight, because growth is bounded, not exponential.
- Nothing catastrophic or amazing happens unattended. The game is stable while you're gone, not exciting.

Quick checkup (30 seconds — "on the bus")

- A single screen reporting status on Catchers/Trainers: who caught what, who leveled, who's low on morale, anything needing a decision.

- Collect income, restock consumables, glance at incoming challenger telegraphs.

Active management (multi-minute sessions)

- Staff and reassign trainers across roles, routes, gyms, and facilities.
- React to telegraphed challengers by reordering your gym/Elite Four lineup.
- Resolve events: professor visits, morale crises, suspensions, post-loss recovery, day care decisions.
- Reinvest income into upgrades, new hires, facility tiers.

The loop repeats: **staff → assign → let it run → react to events → reinvest → repeat.**

3. Roles (The Anti-Duplicate System)

Every trainer in your employ is one of several types. This is the mechanism that turns "box full of useless Pidgeys" into "workforce."

Role	Function	Notes
Catcher	Sent to routes to capture wild Pokémon	Feeds the roster/box economy directly
Battler	Route combat, primary income generation	The bulk of your workforce
Trainer/Coach	Staffed at training facilities; levels up <i>other</i> trainers' Pokémon	This is the "exp share, done properly" fix — see Section 4

Role	Function	Notes
Gym Leader	Type-bound; staffed at a gym; first line of defense against climbing challengers	Order is reassignable — this is your main tactical lever
Elite Four	Type-bound; top tier; last line before a challenger reaches the Champion	Losing this line risks the title itself

A weak or duplicate Pokémon isn't dead weight — it's a Catcher's field partner, a rookie Battler's starter, or fodder at a coaching facility. Every mon in the box has a plausible job.

4. Growth & The Exp-Share Fix

The classic idle-game failure mode: one mon gets a type advantage, wins repeatedly, and

comes back 15 levels ahead of everything else.

Fix: Experience gain is **per-assignment and capped**, not global.

- Each route/facility assignment has a difficulty tier and a level ceiling tied to the trainer's role and equipment.
 - A Coach-staffed facility is the primary way to move levels between mons deliberately — it's a controlled, player-directed version of exp share, not an automatic global broadcast.
 - No single trainer/mon combo can snowball past the ceiling regardless of type matchups. Progress is steady and bounded, which keeps the whole roster relevant instead of collapsing to one ace.
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5. The Challenger System

Challengers are the game's threat and pacing mechanism — and the mechanism that makes "losing" a twist instead of a game-over screen.

How a challenge resolves:

- A challenger fights through your Gym Leaders and Elite Four *in order*. Each matchup outcome is driven by type/strength comparison.
- Example: a Fire-type challenger with a strong Charizard clears a Grass gym easily, struggles against Rock, and the outcome down the line depends on what the player has in place.

Telegraphing (critical – this is what makes losses feel fair):

- Incoming challengers are shown to the player ahead of time: rough type, strength, and a prediction of how far they're likely to get ("Likely to clear Grass & Fighting. Expected to struggle vs. Rock.").
- This gives the player a real tactical decision: reorder the gym/Elite Four lineup, reinforce a weak point, or accept the risk.

Idle/AFK rule:

- While the player is actively playing (checking in at normal cadence), the League **cannot lose** to a challenger – defense always holds.

- If the player goes idle for an extended period (e.g., ~1 week), this protection lapses: a challenger *can* get through a gym or two, denting morale or triggering a suspension.
 - On return, the player gets a soft cushion (a returning-player bonus — discounted rehiring, a free professor visit, etc.) to recover without spiraling.
 - (*Open question: exact idle threshold and exact shape of the "small punishment" — flagged in Section 9.*)
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6. Losing the Title — Forced Recruitment, Not Game Over

If a challenger clears every Gym Leader, every Elite Four member, and beats the Champion — **they become the new Champion.**

This is not a loss state. It's a twist:

- The player, as Director, now manages this new Champion — including their ego, loyalty, and risk of being poached by a rival league (flavor-level, not a deep system).

- The new Champion has **temporary protection** from being fired or demoted — they can't just be immediately benched because they had a lucky run.
- The player's actual goal after this event: **out-develop the rest of the roster** so the league isn't permanently defined by one outsider's win streak. This reuses every system already in the game (staffing, training, morale) rather than introducing a punishment mechanic.

This single mechanic answers three problems at once: it removes the need for a hard "game over," it gives losing narrative weight, and it turns your existing management systems into the comeback path.

7. Morale & Suspension

Losing isn't just narrative — it has a mechanical consequence, but one with a recovery path (no infinite downward spiral).

- **Losses reduce morale.** Low morale reduces performance, or the trainer may request their

own demotion to a lower-pressure role (e.g., Elite Four → Gym Leader).

- **Sustained low morale → Suspension.** The trainer becomes unavailable for a period and returns at reduced standing.
- **Repeated suspensions on the same trainer → permanent departure.** This is escalating, not infinite — it takes real neglect to lose someone for good.
- **Recovery paths:** wins, rest (bench time), or voluntary demotion to reduce pressure. Demotion is a release valve, not just a punishment — it's a legitimate way to preserve a trainer you like without cutting them.

8. The Professor Loop

Periodically, a Professor offers the player something — a gift with a real trade-off attached, not a pure freebie.

Prodigy Trainer offer:

- A trainer with real upside but a genuine flaw (bad type coverage, poor stats, an attitude

problem).

- Accepting costs a wage slot and likely a training investment: assigning a mentor-trainer to grind them, which pulls that mentor off their own normal job for a while.
- Declining isn't free either — the prodigy may end up strengthening a rival league instead (flavor-level, raises the ceiling on future challengers).

Egg offer:

- Hatches into something **rare, not strong** — unique skins, starter-tier Pokémon, collection value rather than raw power.
 - Deliberately not a power-creep mechanic; it's a collection/flavor reward.
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9. Day Care / Breeding

Unlocked later in progression, not available from the start. Deliberately gated — breeding should not be an easy, always-on resource tap.

(Open question: exact gating mechanism — cost, unlock condition, and ongoing restrictions on

breed frequency/output. Flagged below.)

10. Economy (Sketch)

- **Currency: real money.** You pay trainer wages — this is the central resource tension of the whole game.
- **Progression is headcount-driven, not stat-driven:** getting "stronger" mostly means being able to afford *more and better trainers*, which produces stronger Pokémon, which sustains a stronger league.
- Losing a challenge may cost prize money paid to the challenger, adding pressure at the exact moment income is already tight — a deliberate tension, cushioned by the morale/demotion system rather than a hard fail state.

(Open question: actual numbers — income per route tier, wage per role, upgrade costs, prize payouts. This is a balancing pass, not a concept question — flagged below.)

11. Rival Leagues

Present as **flavor only** at this stage — the origin point for challengers and the destination for rejected prodigies/poached trainers. Not a deep, persistent system in this version of the concept.

12. Open Questions / Next Steps

Roughly in order of how much they'll shape the build:

1. **Idle-punishment specifics** — exact idle-time threshold (is it exactly a week?), what "a challenger can get through" means mechanically (does it cost a gym leader morale hit? a suspension?), and the exact shape of the returning-player cushion.
2. **Day care / breeding gating** — what unlocks it, what limits it once unlocked (cooldowns? cost? success rate?), so it stays a deliberate choice rather than a free resource tap.
3. **Economy numbers** — income per route/tier, wage costs per role, upgrade costs, prize

payouts on a loss. Needs a balancing pass, not a conversation.

4. **Session UI** — what the "quick checkup" screen actually shows and how the deeper management screens are organized.
Design/UX work once systems are locked.
 5. **Rival league depth** — confirmed flavor-only for now, but worth revisiting once the core loop is prototyped, in case it wants to grow into a real system later.
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13. Why This Works

- **Solves the duplicate-Pokémon problem** by giving every mon a role in an organization instead of a bench spot on one team.
- **Solves the runaway-snowball problem** with capped, per-assignment growth instead of global exp share.
- **Solves the "no stakes without game over" problem** by making a loss a forced recruitment event, not a fail state — the player's own systems (staffing, training, morale) become the comeback path.

- **Solves the "idle games are unfair when you're not looking" problem** by guaranteeing defense while actively played, and only introducing risk after genuine, extended neglect — with a cushion on return.
- **Differentiates from every existing Pokémon-idle clone** by changing the player's identity from *trainer* to *institution*, which is a premise none of the genre's existing games have tried.